

NORTH VIETNAMESE LEADER (1907–86)

LE DUAN

Preparations for the 1972 invasion of the South were masterminded by Le Duan. A veteran strategist, who had led the Viet Minh against the French in the Mekong in the 1950s, Le Duan became the effective ruler of North Vietnam after Ho Chi Minh's death in 1969, eclipsing rival Pham Van Dong. Evidence suggests that Le Duan took part in a 1967 purge of pro-Soviet leaders that had marginalized Dong.



» AFTER

North Vietnam's preparations for war did not go unnoticed by US intelligence.

NIXON VISITS CHINA

While North Vietnam prepared for its **Easter Offensive**, President Nixon visited China in February 1972, with a view to building relations with Vietnam's ally and isolating Vietnam politically. Peace talks between the North Vietnamese and Henry Kissinger continued in Paris. Hanoi worried that a Chinese-American rapprochement had begun at its expense.

TIME TO STRIKE

By its military offensive, Hanoi sought both to demonstrate its resolve and **break the deadlock** in the peace talks. It believed the US was **stalling for time in the peace talks** while Washington rebuilt the military capabilities of the South Vietnamese.